

Education

Ph.D. in Technology and Social Behavior (TSB)

2020 - 2026 (Expected)

Joint PhD Program in Computer Science and Communication Studies
Northwestern University, Evanston, IL
Advisor: Dr. Nicholas Diakopoulos

B.Eng. in Computer Science

Birla Institute of Technology and Science (BITS) Pilani, Goa, India
Thesis Advisors: Dr. Luís Amaral, Dr. Bharat Deshpande

Research Experience

Computational Journalism Lab, Northwestern University

2020 - Now

Graduate Student Researcher, advised by Dr. Nicholas Diakopoulos

LINK Lab, Northwestern University

2021 - Now

Graduate Student Researcher, mentored by Dr. Ágnes Horvát

Microsoft Research, New York (FATE)

2024

Summer Research Intern, mentored by Dr. Jenn Wortman Vaughan

Microsoft Research, India

2020

Summer Research Intern, mentored by Dr. Joyojeet Pal

Amaral Lab, Northwestern University

2019 - 2020

Affiliate Researcher, mentored by Dr. Luís Amaral

Divecha Centre for Climate Change, Indian Institute of Science (IISc)

2018 - 2019

Affiliate Researcher, mentored by Dr. Rajiv Chaturvedi

Honors and Awards

Best Paper Honorable Mention, ACM DIS

2025

Selected to attend Human-Computer Interaction Consortium (HCIC)

2025

Selected to attend CSST Summer Institute

2025

ACM SIGCHI Gary Marsden Travel Award

2025

David Zarefsky Graduate Fellowship, Northwestern

2024

Cohere For AI Research Grant (\$2,000)

2024

Undergraduate Summer Research Awards, BITS Pilani

2018

Service

Program Committee Member for ACM IUI (2026), ACM CHI Posters (2026), ACM FAccT (2024, 2026), ACM DIS Works-in-Progress (2025)

Peer Reviewer for ACM CHI (2023, 2024*, 2025, 2026), ACM CSCW (2022, 2023*, 2024, 2025*, 2026), ACM DIS (2023*, 2024, 2025*), ACM IUI (2024), ACM FAccT (2026), Digital Journalism (2025), Journalism Studies (2024), NAACL Queer in AI Workshop (2024, 2025), ACM UIST (2023*, 2025), NeurIPS Algorithmic Fairness Workshop (2024), CHI Generative AI and HCI Workshop (2024), AAAI's AI Magazine (2023), NordiCHI (2022).

** indicates special recognition for peer review*

Student Volunteer for ACM DIS (2025), ACM FaccT (2023)

Community Engagement

Co-organizer for PhD Book Club at HCI+Design Center, Northwestern	2022 - 2025
Co-organizer for HCI+News Research Lunches at ACM CSCW and ACM CHI	2023 - 2025
Peer Mentor for Incoming PhD Students, TSB Program, Northwestern	2021 - Now
Community Event Organizer , TSB Program, Northwestern	2021 - Now

Teaching

Communicating Around, About, and With AI , COMM 394**, Northwestern University Instructor of Record, ~15 undergrad students expected.	2026
Digital Propaganda and Repression , COMM 395, Northwestern University Teaching Assistant, 14 Comm. Studies majors.	2024
Compiler Construction , CS F363, BITS Pilani Head Teaching Assistant, ~200 C.S. majors.	2020
Environment, Development and Climate Change , GS F212, BITS Pilani Head Teaching Assistant, 25 undergrad students from diverse majors.	2018
How LLMs Mimic Human Language , Workshop, Northwestern University Co-Instructor, ~15 students. Part of the <i>Computing Everywhere</i> *** Initiative.	2025
Learning Python with EarSketch , Workshop, Northwestern University Co-Instructor, ~35 students in 2025 edition. Initially part of the <i>Computing Everywhere</i> *** Initiative, taught as part of the Northwestern School of Communication's COMM 101 curriculum since 2024.	2022 - Now

Writing seminar and *Computing workshops that are proposed, designed and taught by PhD students.

Invited Talks

Evaluating Generative AI in the Newsroom <i>Aspen Digital AI & News Conference</i> , Ford Foundation, New York City, USA	2024
<i>SRCCON</i> , Minneapolis, USA (with E. Ulken)	2023
Designing / Experimenting with AI in the Newsroom <i>AI in Local Journalism</i> , Northwestern University Medill School, Chicago, USA	2025
<i>Chicago Public Media</i> , Chicago, USA (with M. Cai)	2024
<i>Journalism and Women Symposium</i> , Chicago, USA (with M. Cai)	2023
<i>Story Discovery at Scale Conference</i> , Stanford University, Palo Alto, USA	2023
Creativity and Implicit Bias with Generative AI <i>CoDeX Symposium</i> , Northwestern University, Evanston, USA	2025
<i>Story Discovery at Scale Conference</i> , Stanford University, Palo Alto, USA	2024

Public Writing

Generative AI in Newsroom (GAIN) Blog Contributing posts for industry-facing blog on AI in journalism.	2023 - Now
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Personal Research Blog

Writing about my research projects, conferences, and recent reading.

2023 - Now

BITS Goa R&D Blog

Editorial team member and contributor.

2018 - 2020

Research Mentorship

Eric Lee, Undergraduate student at Northwestern University

2024

Jasmine Wu, Undergraduate student at Northwestern University

2022

Under Review and In Preparation Papers

[U3] **Caged Birds and Cute Bookworms: Implicit Gender Bias in Narratives by Large Language Models**

S. Nishal and J. Bandy

Under review at ACL Rolling Review.

[U2] **News Compass: A Computational Tool for Enabling Field Awareness in Science Journalism**

S. Nishal, Á. Horvát, N. Diakopoulos

In preparation for ACM C&C 2026.

[U1] **Towards Ecologically Valid LLM Benchmarks: Understanding and Designing Domain-Centered Evaluations for Journalism Practitioners**

C. Li, N. Hagar, **S. Nishal**, J. Gilbert, N. Diakopoulos

In preparation for ACM DIS 2026.

Peer Reviewed Papers

[P7] **"Helping Me Versus Doing It for Me": Designing for Agency in LLM-Infused Writing Support Tools for Science Journalism**

S. Nishal, M. Lee, N. Diakopoulos, J. W. Vaughan

Conditionally accepted to *ACM CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI)*, 2026

[P6] **Values as Problems, Principles, and Tensions in Sociotechnical System Design for Journalism**

S. Nishal and N. Diakopoulos

Proceedings of the ACM Conference on Designing Interactive Systems (DIS), 2025

Best Paper Honorable Mention

[P5] **Understanding Practices around Computational News Discovery Tools in the Domain of Science Journalism[†]**

S. Nishal, J. Sinchai, N. Diakopoulos

Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction (CSCW), 2024

[P4] **From Crowd Ratings to Predictive Models of Newsworthiness to Support Science Journalism**

S. Nishal, N. Diakopoulos

Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction (CSCW), 2022

[P3] **Voting with the Stars: Analyzing Partisan Engagement between Celebrities and Politicians in India**

R. Mothilal, D. Mishra, **S. Nishal**, F. Lalani, J. Pal

Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction (CSCW), 2022

[P2] **DISMISS: Database of Indian Social Media Influencers (Snowballed Sequentially) on Twitter**

A. Arya, S. De, D. Mishra, G. Shekhawat, A. Sharma, A. Panda, F. Lalani, P. Singh, R. Mothilal, R. Grover, **S. Nishal**, S. Dash, S. Rashid, S. Akbar, J. Pal

Proceedings of the International AAAI Conference on Web and Social Media (ICWSM), 2022

[P1] **Devotees on an Astroturf: Media, Politics, and Outrage in the Suicide of a Popular FilmStar**

S.Z. Akbar, A. Sharma, D. Mishra, R.K. Mothilal, H. Negi, **S. Nishal**, A. Panda, J. Pal

Workshops Organized

- [O2] **News Futures: Sociotechnical Systems for News Production and Consumption**
S. Nishal, M. Aubin Le Quéré, B. McInnis, B. Jones, K. Vaccaro, T. Aitamurto, M. Naaman, N. Diakopoulos
ACM CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems, 2025
- [O1] **Evaluating Generative AI Tools in Your Newsroom**
C. Li, **S. Nishal**, N. Diakopoulos
Computation+Journalism Symposium (C+J), 2024

Workshop Papers and Posters (Lightly Reviewed)

- [W11] **News Futures: (Re-)Designing Sociotechnical Systems for News Production and Consumption**
S. Nishal, M. Aubin Le Quéré, B. McInnis, B. Jones, K. Vaccaro, T. Aitamurto, M. Naaman, N. Diakopoulos
Extended Abstracts of the CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI EA), 2025
Co-lead workshop organizer at CHI 2025
- [W10] **Designing for Agency in LLM-Infused Writing Support Tools for Science Journalism**
S. Nishal, M. Lee, N. Diakopoulos, J. W. Vaughan
Workshop on Tools for Thought at ACM CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems, 2025
- [W9] **"Good enough" news? Generative AI's Impacts on Local News Reporting**
N. Hagar and **S. Nishal**
Pre-conference on AI in Journalism From a Global Perspective at ICA Annual Conference, 2025
- [W8] **De-jargonizing Science for Journalists with GPT-4: A Pilot Study[†]**
S. Nishal, E. Lee, N. Diakopoulos
Computation + Journalism Symposium (C+J), 2024
- [W7] **Domain-Specific Evaluation Strategies for AI in Journalism**
S. Nishal, C. Li, N. Diakopoulos
Workshop on Evaluating AI at ACM CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems, 2024
- [W6] **How Film Festivals Navigate Algorithmic Film Curation**
S. Nishal and V. Nguyen.
Workshop on Political Imaginaries in HCI at the ACM Conference on Designing Interactive Systems (DIS), 2023
- [W5] **Envisioning the Applications and Implications of Generative AI in the Newsroom**
S. Nishal, N. Diakopoulos
Workshop on Generative AI and HCI at ACM CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems, 2023
- [W4] **Motivations, Goals, and Pathways for AI Literacy for Journalism**
S. Nishal, M. Cai
Workshop on AI Literacy at ACM CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems, 2023
- [W3] **Designing Interactive, Configurable and Transparent Algorithmic Systems to Support Journalistic Decision-Making**
S. Nishal
Doctoral Consortium at ACM Conference on Fairness, Accountability, and Transparency (FAccT), 2023
- [W2] **Measuring the Impact of Trope-based Novelty on Film Success**
S. Nishal, L. A. N. Amaral
International Conference on Computational Social Science (IC2S2), 2022
- [W1] **AI-Driven News Recommender Systems for Science Journalists**

